assembly poll. A survey by its own data analytics department indicated that the party should have formed a pre-poll alliance with the ruling TMC. Yet, the Congress did not go down that route. The party squandered its opportunities in Uttarakhand and Goa too, where the anti-incumbency against the BJP governments ran high.

But none of it seems to be one lesson too many for the Congress. If party insiders, including Gandhi family loyalists, are to be believed, the party is yet to stir into action in states scheduled to go to polls this year and the next. In Gujarat, for instance, where the election is due later this year, its top leader Hardik Patel has openly expressed resentment against the party and there has been no decision on inducting Naresh Patel, an influential leader of the Patidar community that holds sway in 48 of the state's 182 assembly seats even as other parties are wooing him.

The party's inability or unwillingness to take fast and timely decisions has been one of its major failings. Several Congress leaders believe the party won three elections in 2018 and put up a strong fight in Gujarat in 2017 because it took faster decisions. All of them, regardless of age and allegiance, agree that the party's inertia in decision-making is rooted in its culture of consensus-building, which has reached another level under the Gandhi trio. Not taking a decision is often a strategy adopted to avoid confrontation and maintain the status quo. Thus, elections in Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh are scheduled for next year, yet no visible effort has been made to stop the feud over the chief ministerial chair from spilling out in public. There is no clarity on state leadership in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh, two states headed for polls later this year.

Who will be the leader?

The party's real problem is that the three Gandhis continue to exert a collective and individual hold over the party. Rahul may have relinquished the post of party president, owning responsibility for the crushing Lok Sabha defeat in 2019, and mother Sonia taken over as 'interim' president, but his consent is still sought in party decisions. Priyanka often acts as consensus-builder between mother and son, but every so often, she acts on her own preferences, as in the Navjot Sidhu case in July 2021 or in engaging with Kishor recently.

The trio may take decisions collectively, but each has a mind and functioning style of their own, sending mixed signals within the party. Sonia depends on the counsel of senior leaders, and acutely feels the

INTERVIEW
P. CHIDAMBARAM

"WHY CAN'T A 40-YEAR-OLD BE CONGRESS PRESIDENT?"

Former Union finance and home minister and Congress Working Committee member **P. Chidambaram** *is* a key policymaker in the Congress. In an exclusive interview with *Executive Editor* **Kaushik Deka**, the veteran leader explains why the party needs to nurture younger leaders

Q. Why is the Congress facing an existential crisis?

The Congress is a natural party of governance. We know how to run a government. But when we run the government, we fail to run the party. Most senior leaders are inducted into the government and not spared for party work. When Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh were prime ministers, we neglected the party organisation. Because the party machinery and work were neglected, when we are in the Opposition, the party organisation has not picked up the responsibilities or carried the party's message and narrative.

Q. How do you plan a revival when the party is almost non-existent in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, West Bengal, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh and a junior partner in Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra? These states account for nearly 300 seats.

The Congress's decline in states such as UP, Bihar, West Bengal predates even the tenure of Narasimha Rao. The origins of the decline in these states are very different. Under the current circumstances, I would divide the states into three categories—states where the Congress is the principal opposition to the BJP, states where another party is the principal opposition to the BJP and Congress is an ally of that party, and finally states where another party is the principal opposition to the BJP and Congress is not in alliance with it.

The challenge lies in category one and category three. We need different strategies for the three categories of states. In category one, I will not write off the Congress. For instance, in Rajasthan, we won the assembly poll but lost every seat in Lok Sabha elections. In MP also, we won the state election but lost all but one seat in parliamentary elections.